



Red-letter day: In just his first year wearing Bangladesh's colours, Hamza Choudhury has captured the hearts of fans and played a pivotal role in a historic 1-0 victory over India last November, ending a 26-year wait for a win against their fiercest rivals. RITU RAJ KONWAR

to do," said UK-based midfielder Raj Palit, who has Indian roots.

Palit, who came through the youth systems of Manchester United and Huddersfield Town, added:

"Obviously our family, friends are all here. Ryan moved over with his family and he did it that way. But not everybody is willing to do that."

The debate highlights a core dilemma in India's OCI discussion: how much personal sacrifice can realistically be expected from players who may have never lived in the country they want to represent?

To address this, the Sports Ministry has reportedly forwarded a proposal for a specialised sports passport to the Government of India — one that could allow OCI players to represent the national team without giving up existing citizenship benefits.

Progress, with caveats

While intent appears positive across these developments, questions remain over execution. Will the new commercial structure be sustainable in the long term? In the ISL, will OCI/PIO players be accommodated within existing foreign-player slots or displace Indian players — and if so, how will that balance be managed?

Under current rules, an ISL club

can sign up to six foreign players, including one Asian quota player, but can field only four. Any delay in finalising slot distribution could disrupt transfer planning across clubs. Above all, whether introducing OCI/PIO players will meaningfully improve Indian football remains an open question.

Pakistan's national football team offers a cautionary parallel: despite a long-standing openness to dual-citizenship players and captains born outside the country, its FIFA ranking fell from 193 to 201 between October 2023 and April 2026.

Indian football may finally be emerging from its administrative maze. Whether it avoids building a new one through delayed decisions and half-measures will define the next two years.



Diaspora debate: Former Australia U-23 international Ryan Williams switched allegiance to India and marked his senior debut with a goal that secured the country's first win in nearly seven months in March 2026.

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